control of the Gulf region. Caroe also argued that the stability of the Middle East depended on British control of an undivided India, and with its break-up Pakistan would have to take over this role.[50]

On the other hand, India's founding fathers had a different vision for India's engagement with the rest of the world. For Nehru, India, as one of two main Asian civilizations, would symbolize the rise of Asia. A few months before Independence, in March 1947, he championed the Asian Relations Conference that was held in Delhi and was attended by delegates from many parts of Asia, even from countries that were still under colonial rule. Nehru believed that India had been forced to participate in imperial adventures against its will and that independent India would not send its troops out of the country. Indian reluctance to send its troops, except under UN mandate, is a legacy of this colonial past in addition to being influenced by its ancient isolationist history.

Some Indians, like Panikkar, saw Independence as an opportunity for India's rise and embraced the views of British strategists about India's centrality in influencing the Near and Far East. Panikkar saw benefits for India in associating closely with Britain and maintaining, as a sovereign country, the policies of regional primacy that had been devised for the British Empire. He described a Triune Commonwealth: 'a reconstituted Indian empire, on the basis of the freedom of India, Pakistan and Burma'. [51] In a 1919 pamphlet *Indian Nationalism*, Panikkar and an unnamed British colleague had called for the need to 'knit India to England and England to India in a free partnership'. [52]

Decades later Panikkar explained his view thus: 'The old Indian empire as a common defence area had much in its favour. It included Aden, as an outpost, kept the Persian Gulf and the Oman coast within the orbit of Indian policy, neutralized Tibet and held strongly to the Eastern frontier of Burma.' For Panikkar, the 'surrender' of Aden to the colonial office was 'the first short-sighted step' that led to the breakup of this scheme. Other drastic steps